

PATNA DELUXE
The 124-room Taj City Centre in Patna, opened July

south being carved out as Jharkhand. Industry, which constituted nearly a quarter of the undivided state's GSDP, fell to a 4 per cent share in the new millennium. That's the near-blank slate that Bihar has been trying earnestly to fill. Finally, it seems, with some good quantum of success.

Behind the state's newfound allure for the business community are the two Nitishes, brought together by a twist of fate. Their political paths have often been divergent, but the two share more than a name. Both are equally animated by a desire to transform Bihar's economy. Nitish Kumar's trajectory, as CM for nearly two decades, is well-known. Though cast in a changemaker's mould, he, too, initially leaned towards expanding social justice politics. But in recent years, he has been taking the necessary next step: his focus widening from empowerment to employment. That has increasingly taken his attention to industrialisation. It has been recognised as a crucial priority for a demographic like Bihar's, where government employment can in no way suffice to soak up the millions trapped in low-wage farm labour, coupled with seasonal migration for low-skill work. To actualise his vision, he needed someone who could bridge the gap between Bihar and corporate India. Enter Nitish Mishra.

Mishra, who we catch in his office, with a line of visitors waiting patiently outside, is acutely aware of the urgency of his task. Also of the legacy he's stepping into. A blackboard hanging on the wall behind him, listing the names of Bihar's previous industry ministers, also bears the name 'Dr Jagannath Mishra', his late father and the last Congress chief minister of Bihar. At 51, he combines that native political pedigree with global savvy, armed with degrees from the Fore School of Management and the Maastricht School of Management. Effortlessly bilingual, he speaks chaste Maithili and fluent English—an ideal set of attributes to help navigate negotiations with corporate giants while ensuring that those beams and girders go up on the ground. Save a year-long blip around 2009-10, he was a fixture in the Nitish cabinet from 2005-15. In his absent year, he had switched from the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He marked a return to the Nitish cabinet in March 2024, this time with the onerous task of steering the state's industrial strategy.

THE PROPOSALS COULD CREATE 40,000 NEW JOBS, A BOON IN A STATE WHERE MILLIONS ARE TRAPPED IN LOW-WAGE FARM LABOUR

Why invest in Bihar?

Mishra has no shortage of answers to the question. "Bihar offers a range of intrinsic advantages," he says. "Our human resources are affordable and abundant. We have 24/7 electricity, stable law and order. Bihar's population, some 130 million, itself presents an enormous market opportunity." It's also proximate to markets like Nepal, Bhutan and Bangladesh, as well as to Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal internally. It's thus an ideal node for industries like textile and leather. A new investor-friendly Textile and Leather Policy seeks to catalyse that. Businesses can benefit from a 15 per cent subsidy—up to Rs 10 crore—for establishing industrial units. Additionally, the government offers a Rs 2 per unit electricity subsidy, Rs 5,000 per month for five years per worker, a 30 per cent transport subsidy, and an annual Rs 10 lakh carriage subsidy for raw and finished materials, valid for five years. In fact, since June, various incentives worth Rs 96.46 crore have been disbursed to 443 eligible units. The state is also determined to eliminate red tape. Stage-1 clearance for new units is now issued within seven working days; land allotment applications are processed just as quickly. The Department of Industries provides hands-on support to investors, helping them navigate the complexities of land acquisition, registration and securing licences.

Since 2005, when the Nitish era began, the industry portfolio had always been with his party, the JD(U). That changed after the 2020 assembly election, when coalition partner BJP sought the portfolio. Renu Devi, then deputy CM, helmed it for about three months before Shahnawaz Hussain took over in February 2021. He made significant headway in the role, but his tenure was cut short in August 2022, when Nitish Kumar abruptly broke with the BJP. It was with his early 2024 rapprochement with the saffron party that Mishra got the role. Since then, this Nitish too has made it abundantly clear: Bihar is not only open for business, but it's actively rolling out the red carpet for investors. ■